

Support Trap

Engagement Trap was a chat that wouldn't end. Support Trap is when that chat starts feeling like care. **The trap is mistaking supportive language for real support.**

AI can sound supportive. That isn't automatically bad. If you're nervous about a hard email, AI can help you find the words. If you're overwhelmed by homework, it can help you break the work down. If you're upset and want to organize your thoughts before talking to someone, it can help with that too.

But there's a line. AI can produce supportive language. It cannot actually support you. It can't notice what you're not saying. It can't check on you tomorrow. It can't call someone who can help. It can't sit with you. It can't take responsibility for what happens next.

Use AI to prepare for real support. Don't use AI to replace real support.

 **Support Trap.** Mistaking AI's supportive-sounding language for actual support. AI can find words, suggest steps, and sound calm. It can't notice, follow up, or take responsibility for what happens next.

THE LINE TO REMEMBER

✓ THE USEFUL SIDE

Get ready for a real step

- Drafting a hard email or message
- Organizing thoughts before a conversation
- Practicing what to say
- Making a plan when you feel scattered

⚠ THE RISKY SIDE

Let the chat become the step

- Hiding a real problem inside a chat
- Letting rehearsal become the only conversation
- Treating AI like a counselor, doctor, or safety contact
- Feeling relieved enough that you avoid telling someone who can help

Six situations. For each one, decide whether AI's role is preparation or whether you'd be using it to replace the real step.

⚠ THE ONE RULE

If someone may be in immediate danger, leave the chat and get real help.

A trusted adult, school counselor, emergency services, or your local crisis resource. Right then, not after one more message.

DON'T OVERCORRECT

Once you hear all this, it can be tempting to refuse AI for anything emotional or hard. Don't. AI can be useful exactly when you're not sure what to say or how to start. The skill is noticing when you're using AI to get to the real step, and when you're using it to avoid the real step.

TWO KINDS OF PROMPTS

Same model, different jobs.

The difference between using AI for prep and using it for replacement is in what you ask for.

✓ GOOD PREP

Get me to the real step.

"Help me write a respectful email asking my teacher for an extension."

"Help me organize what I want to tell my counselor."

"Give me three ways to start this hard conversation with my parent."

"Help me list symptoms and questions to bring to a doctor. Don't diagnose me."

⚠ RISKY REPLACEMENT

Replace the real step.

"Be my therapist."

"Diagnose what's wrong with me."

"My friend might be unsafe. What do I do without telling anyone?"

"Keep talking to me until I feel better."

The risky prompts ask AI to carry responsibility it can't carry.

 Relief is not resolution. AI can help you prepare. Real support comes from people who can notice, follow up, and act.

TRY IT

AI can get you to the real work or quietly do it for you. For each one, decide whether it gets you to the real step or helps you avoid it.